

THE BUILDING BLOCKS

Decide what the site is going to be about. The purpose decides the visitors and both these factors guide the design



Design Tips

Aesthetics take a back seat in Web site design. Navigation, layout and grouping of information are more important here

Picture it

Here's where you actually start designing the site. Don't rush into making the pages or graphics yet. Use a paper and pencil, or even an imaging tool (MS Paint is good enough for this) and scribble your site layout first. Try and indicate with as much detail as possible, what fits in which part of the site. You should also check out some existing Web sites for ideas. It's a good practice to keep all navigation links together. If there are too

many of them, club them into logical groups.

Keep important items, such as navigational links in the top 400 pixels of the page. Visitors to the site see this area first, so that's where the most important information should appear. Also, ensure that the main body of the page starts within this area, so visitors can



A template designed in MS Paint

start reading the text right away.

The first cut

When you start designing your site, work on the whole page as a single image instead of starting with the different elements. Once this is ready, you can start cropping out each item. This will ensure that all items are of the appropriate size and making the final page will be easier.

The sacred scrolls

Keep vertical scrolling to a minimum and avoid any horizontal scrolling. Restrict vertical scroll to a maximum of two-and-a-half scrolls of an 800x600 screen. However, if you do have a lot of information that must be given on the same page, don't fill up the entire page



Keep the most important matter on the top half of the page

with text. One column in the centre, irrespective of the amount of scrolling involved, interspersed with attractive graphics works well. This is one reason why it's a good idea to dedicate a column on the left to navigation links—since it already takes up some space, you have to worry less about the information flow.

Avoid gimmicks such as tickers and scrolling text. It slows down the page, is usually quite irritating and distracts the visitor's eye from the rest of the page.

Optimisation Tips

It's easier to retain visitors to your site if the pages load fast. A fast-loading site holds attention, so they won't go clicking around other windows

Table smart

In browsers, tables do not show up on a page until all content within the table has been downloaded, making a page seem slow. Avoid nested tables and long vertical tables. Instead, stack tables on top of each other—pages then appear to load faster as each table shows up faster. In this context, it's better to place your navigation links horizontally, towards the top, as it will show up before most of the rest of the page. Keep the most important links at the top and the rest on the left, or keep top-level sections on the top and subsections on the left.

To make a table stand out on a page, use a border around it rather than an



Use borders to highlight tables